

COLORADO FIELD ORNITHOLOGISTS - SIGHT RECORD FORM

7-0 (A)

Red 12/8/00 upl

NEW STATE RECORD _____ UNUSUAL RECORD _____

Species: Lesser Black-backed Gull (*Larus fuscus graellsii*)**Date:** 15 October & 12 November 2000 **Number seen:** one **Sex:** ? **Plumage:** Def. Basic**Locality:** Cherry Creek Res.**Elevation:** about 5350'**Nearest town:** Aurora**County:** Arapahoe**Time observed:** about 10:55-11:20 MDT (10/15) and about 10:30-10:45 MST (11/12)**Duration of observation:** about 10 minutes in all

Description: While looking through the gulls at Cherry Creek Res., Doug Faulkner found an adult Lesser Black-backed Gull (LBBG) among the many Ring-bills and Californias (CAGU). On 15 October, the bird was at the marina; on 12 November, it was in the southeast corner of the reservoir (in a flock that had another LBBG in it - submitted separately).

The bird was slightly bigger and much darker-mantled than the nearby CAGUs, though the mantle was much paler than that on the Great Black-backed Gull nearby. The head was noticeably more angular than those of the CAGUs and it was white with thick brown streaking. The streaking coalesced around the eyes into darker patches, but there were obvious white eye arcs; the forehead was unmarked. There was also a faint dark eyeline from the loreal area to behind the eye. The bill was yellow with a large, red gonydeal spot apparently extending up onto the maxilla. The bill had a much stronger gonydeal angle than that on a CAGU. The eyes were yellow.

The underparts were white, but the chest had brown mottling. The bird had thin, white tertial and scapular crescents. P10 had a large mirror that did not reach the feather tip and P9 had a small mirror and there were no white tips to the primaries as at least the outer primaries were old and the white tips had worn off. Because of this, I was unable to determine the number of primary tips beyond the tail tip, but the primary tip projection beyond the tail was about longer than the distance from the tail tip to the tip of the lowermost tertial. The tail was all white. The tibiae were grayish-pink and the rest of the legs were pink. Though I could not detect any signs of immaturity on this bird (e.g., brown feathers in the mantle or strong, dark markings on the bill), I never saw the bird fly, so cannot be sure that it was a full adult. However, even full adults can have pink legs - apparently as many as 3% (Grant 1986).

Similar species eliminated: California Gull (CAGU) eliminated by size, mantle color, and bill size and shape. HERG (*smithsonianus*) ruled out by mantle color. Other, darker forms of HERG ruled out by size (they should be larger). Slaty-backed Gull (SBGU) eliminated by wing pattern (number of mirrors and color of secondaries, the visible parts of which should be mostly white), and mantle color (the bird was not virtually black-backed). Kelp Gull (KEGU) ruled out by bill (size and shape) and by mantle color. Great Black-backed Gull eliminated by size and by upperparts color and pattern.

Describe the bird's song and call, if given, including method of delivery (i.e. from perch, in flight, duration): No vocalizations heard.

What is your prior experience with this and similarly-appearing species? I have seen >85 *graellsii* LBBGs on the Great Lakes and the East Coast and >10 previously in CO, bazillions of *smithsonianus* HERGs, >125 *vegae* HERGs, 10s of 1000s of GBBGs, 1000s of CAGUs, and >75 SBGUs. I have not seen any other of the darker, Asian HERGs, nor have I seen KEGU.

Light conditions: sun was to my right and in front of me on 10/15, behind and to my left on 11/12

Optical equipment used: Leica 32x and Swarovski 8x42

Distance, and how estimated: estimated closest distance at about 100 meters

Other observers who saw the bird with you: Doug Faulkner (10/15) and Larry Semo and Michael Patten (11/12)

Other observers who saw the bird independently: Joey Kellner and Andy Spencer on 11/12, presumably others during its long stay

If photographed, type of equipment and film: I did not photograph the bird.

List books, illustrations, recordings, other birders, etc. consulted and how this influenced your identification:

a) at time of observation: none

b) after observation: none

Reporting observer: Tony Leukering

Signature:



Address: Colorado Bird Observatory, 13401 Picadilly Road, Brighton, CO 80601

Date report was written: 5 December 2000 from notes written during the sighting

Literature Cited

Grant, P. J. 1986. Gulls: A Guide to Identification, 2nd ed. Buteo Books, Vermilion, SD.